



Figure 4: The Computer Janitor

network connection status changes, print job status changes, new e-mails, etc. The default balloon tips no longer appear. They have been replaced by black rectangles appearing near the top right corner of the screen.

The software, called Notify OSD, has received a not-too-excited welcome from the community. Some say it is useless because its position cannot be changed and it cannot show timeout or button widgets like the balloons, while others say it will be fine only if the work goes upstream so that it is included in standard GNOME. On the other hand, most people do like its appearance and the fact that it does not create overlapping notifications. For me, it doesn't matter that much as long as it works correctly.

The software update system now does not show the balloon tip informing of available updates, but launches the Update Manager directly if updates are available. I don't know whether this has been done to prevent out-of-place notifications now that Notify OSD is being used, but the release notes say that you can restore the old behaviour by issuing the following command:

```
gconftool -s --type bool /apps/update-notifier/
auto_launch false
```

Synaptic, the package manager, has also acquired the ability to show screenshots of programs, although many programs don't have screenshots available.

On board, the rest is as usual. The stock software is included and the hardware is detected correctly, including my native screen resolution. My system does not have a separate graphics card, but the unobtrusive 3D effects of the user interface worked smoothly. Suspend/resume worked normally, and there were no freezes. Not finding any updates for my erratic Bluetooth device, however, I tried an alternative called Blueman (Bluetooth Manager), available through a Launchpad PPA (Canonical's custom software packaging service). Its homepage is at blueman-project.org. It replaces *bluez-gnome*, GNOME's default Bluetooth software, and is somewhat more feature-laden. However, it could do nothing for my in-built Bluetooth device, so I changed back to *bluez-gnome*.

You may try it as an alternative if you work with Bluetooth frequently. I settled for my old and trusty USB Bluetooth device. The problem with the in-built one seems to be at a lower level—the kernel perhaps. The problem did not occur in Ubuntu 8.10, but it does occur in Fedora 10.

After a couple of days, I tried the Computer Janitor and it showed me a package that could be removed because it had once satisfied a dependency but was no longer needed now. The Janitor is good to have around to clean up the system if you want to, but it is not likely to be used too frequently since this is GNU/Linux, and especially since this is Debian (I usually remove packages completely, including configuration files, when I uninstall something on Debian).

Good enough

Debian-based systems generally don't depart from the quality levels their parent upholds. It needs to be seen in which direction Canonical's innovations like Notify OSD will go, but on the whole, even in version 9.04, they have maintained their tradition of providing up-to-date, but stable software without show-stopper bugs. The codec installation for proprietary multimedia formats works as usual, except that, in addition to the

flashplugin-nonfree package, which has transitioned to *flashplugin-installer*, an *adobe-flashplugin* package is now available for Adobe Flash. Since it is not clear which one should be installed, I selected *adobe-flashplugin* seeing that it is supported by Canonical, whereas the others are not.

Ubuntu has always been a distribution that's meant to be free as well as suitable for daily, real-life use. It has no paid version carrying proprietary stuff or extra facilities. It does not force experimental features on users and is not a restrictive, special-purpose system. Of course, there is a place for each of these too, and innovation, especially, has been a defining characteristic of GNU/Linux. However, we need the likes of Ubuntu too. I believe it is the integral feel, stability and comprehensiveness of the system that makes Ubuntu viable as an operating system for day-to-day use. At least, all of this has been true of the Ubuntu releases till now. I don't know what the next version, the Karmic Koala, will bring to the table (the newly planted Eucalyptus will hopefully be palatable to the Koala by the time he arrives :-)). Until then, the Jackalope seems to be jaunty enough! 

Ubuntu 9.04



Pros:

Speed, stability, ease of use, professional look and feel, easy support for proprietary hardware and software, high speed repositories.

Cons:

Graphical system administration tools not suitable for advanced use, installer changes hardware clock to UTC without asking.

Platform: x86

Price: Free (as in beer)

Website: www.ubuntu.com

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